Japanese American Influence on Video Game Development

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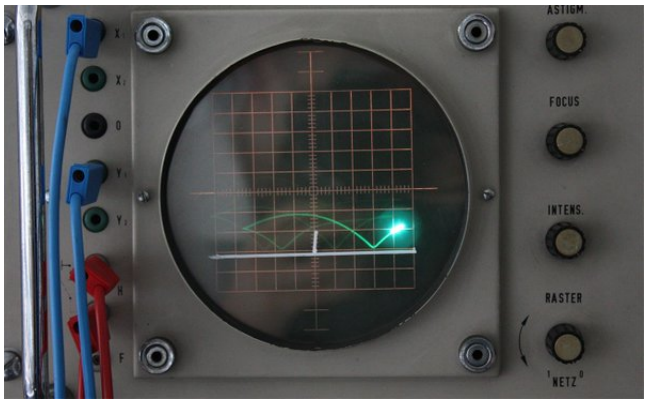
Video games are a new phenomenon that allow us to interact with a simulated world around us. Having only existed for approximately 70 years, we are seeing companies spending more than $10 million USD on titles in a ferocious attempt to compete in today's economy. These video games allow people to take on new personas, tell stories, or build a platform for us to explore. They are used in scientific experiments to study human psychology or in military procedures to simulate training situations. The applications are endless and the demand is ever growing, but rushing into this new industry could prove catastrophic. I would like to take a moment to reflect on how different regions such as United States and Japan are approaching this new technology to see how cultural backgrounds affect the industry, and provoke ideas on where the future of this industry lies.

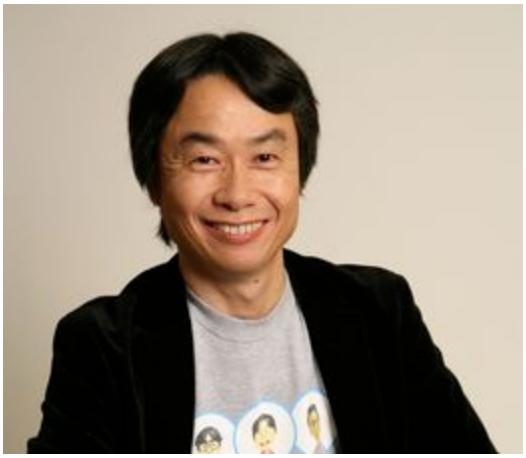
The earliest record of video gaming history can be traced back as far as 1954, 32 years after the release of the cathode ray tube and 9 years after the end of World War 2. The invention of the DVBST would allow the user to project a single beam of light onto a screen and perform drawing motions similar to an "Etch-a-sketch" childrens toy. This technology would soon be introduced to Japan where companies like Sega would create arcade games such as 1965's "Periscope" which saw international release in 1967. After international excitement grew, many new arcade platform games were developed. Namco released driver in 1970 and Nintendo patented the "Magnavox Odyssey" game console in 1974. These companies never began in the tech industry but rather as toy companies. Soon, they transitioned into international giants, each employing approximately 5000 people. For perspective, the first commercially successful game "Pong" by Allan Alcorn was released in the United States in 1972.



1958's "Tennis for Two" played on an Oscilloscope.

It's interesting to note how these development companies continue to compete in today's market. Tech giants like Sega or Nintendo seemed to have taken a "black-box" teamwork based approached where many people work on one project with limited communication in other

departments. These companies reflect heavily on their roots in the 1970's, working to instead push hardware limitations and stick to traditional values on single AAA titles of budgets upward of $10 million USD. In contrast, companies in North America seem to be shifting towards the "indie" market, employing smaller and more integrated teams, proving to be a more successfully competitive force to the massive AAA games. This accurately reflects the history of these two cultures, referring to Japan's influence of Confucianism and rice culture, and the United State's willingness to explore and research new aspects of the surrounding world under heavy capitalist influences. The Auteur movement of Japan, a term originating from the 1940's French film industry, refers to a creative development style where the director oversees all audio and visual elements of a motion picture. Nintendo director Shigeru Miyamoto had the opportunity of designing each level to the 1985's classically successful title "Super Mario Bros", which seemed contrary to the approach taken in the United States where an entire team of developers would share the responsibility and base designs on market trends and target audiences. An example of this could be Ubisoft's 2015 release of "Rainbow Six: Siege" where level design is drastically changed every 6 weeks to better balance player interactions on this competitive platform. Another thing that sets the Japanese Auteur movement apart from the United States indie development is that many of these directors, such as Koji Igarashi or Hironobu Sakaguchi, gained a lot of publicity working in the AAA game development scene and applied their new found fame and experiences trying to perfect the genres that brought them into the spotlight. This differs from the lower budgeted indie games produced in the United States and their attempt to push innovation and accumulate drastically varied marketing data. Many of these games are often referred to by their directors or franchise, bringing with them a massive history of greatness which can sometimes trick the general public into thinking that these projects were originated from one visionary.



Shigeru Miyamoto, the visionary for Mario Bros.

Another key difference between Japanese and American game development is the style of gameplay that can arise. In particular, I'd like to focus on the differences between WRPG's (western role playing games) and JRPG's (Japanese role playing games) as these two genres are both new and unique to this industry. Both of these genres were popularized independently in two different regions. Previously, we saw that Japan released the first ever platformer, "Mario Bros", and in the United States we saw the first "first person" game known as "Doom". Both of these styles stemmed from very different backgrounds. "Mario Bros" is an example of limited technology that had been perfected, while "Doom" pursued technological innovation. However, regarding RPG's, Many Japanese companies like Square Enix or Atlus Japan would start their projects by basing it off of a script or visual novel. The Japanese language utilized kanji which would also allow for more text to be displayed on a limited screen space with the same amount of computer memory. This narrative based approach reflects heavily on Japanese Shintoism and how their belief system is best explained through the creation story. This was further driven by the Otaku culture that rooted from the Japanese anime industry. Franchises like Final Fantasy, Chrono Trigger, or Persona to this day continue to produce narrative role plays where the player must act out according to their character's situation. In the United States however, we see games like "World of Warcraft", "Skyrim", or "Catherine" as games where the player will act according to their personal feelings and intentions. Many role play situations would allow the player to address themselves by their personal name rather than the character they play as. Catherine is a particularly interesting title as the company Atlus originates in both Tokyo, Japan and California, United States. It was produced in America using mechanics from a different Japanese title. It held a role play narrative format but allowed the character to make personal decisions which led to one of many endings. This combined both a linear narrative of a JRPG with dynamic "free roam" mechanics that's often seen in a WRPG.

English translation of Atlus Japan's Persona (2016). The player is subjected to the narrative.

Japanese translation of Atlus America's Catherine (2011). The player chooses their own fate.

The differences between these regions and approaches to the video game industry are both unique in terms of development and marketing. They can also be viewed as reflections of their cultures in terms of aesthetics and design. The future of this industry is ever expanding and perhaps may see more crossovers as international relationships further root themselves. Perhaps someday this platform will be used as a springboard for new technological innovation and as a canvas for deeper artistic expression.

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